

ImmigFlow

Product Requirements Document · v2.0 · April 2026

One sentence: ImmigFlow gives immigration consultants an AI back-office assistant that reads client documents, fills out government forms, and assembles application packages — so consultants can handle twice the caseload without hiring more staff.

What was wrong with the first draft

The first PRD read like a consultant wrote it for a venture capital firm. It had a TAM slide, a competitive landscape grid, and phrases like 'enterprise-level.' Paul Graham would stop reading after page two.

Three specific problems:

- It led with market size. '\$80–120M TAM' is the wrong opening. It tells investors you're thinking about the exit, not the problem. The right opening is a specific person with a specific pain.
- It was vague about the hard parts. Any PRD that doesn't mention that IRCC has no public API, that immigration errors can ruin someone's life, or that AI hallucinations on government forms are catastrophic — is not being honest.
- It targeted everyone. '8,000 active RCICs' is not a target customer. The right target is: the 400 RCIC firms in Ontario and BC that each employ one junior case worker at \$30–40/hour whose entire job is copying passport numbers into PDF forms.

This version fixes those things. It's shorter, more specific, and honest about what's hard.

The problem

Meet Priya. She runs a four-person immigration consulting firm in Brampton. She's an RCIC — a federally licensed professional — and she's genuinely good at her job. When a new client walks in, she knows within twenty minutes which immigration stream fits them, what their chances are, and how to position a tricky work history to IRCC.

Then she hands the file to her case worker, Jordan.

Jordan spends the next six to eight hours doing this: opening the client's passport, typing their name and passport number into a PDF form, opening their diploma, typing the institution name and graduation date into a different field, opening their pay stub, typing their employer's address into a third form.

Cross-referencing that every name spelling is identical across every document. Calculating whether the passport expires within six months of the permit end date. Checking the ESDC wage table to confirm the offered salary meets the prevailing rate for this NOC code in this province.

Jordan is not making any decisions. Jordan is doing copy-paste work that pays \$35 an hour and takes up the entire workday.

Priya's firm can handle about 60 active files at once. That ceiling is not set by Priya's expertise. It's set by how fast Jordan can move paper.

The insight: the bottleneck in every RCIC practice is not the licensed professional — it's the unlicensed case worker doing data entry. That case worker can be replaced by software. No one has built it yet because it requires AI that's good enough at reading documents. That inflection happened in 2023–2024.

Why now

RCIC case management software has existed for fifteen years. RCIC Suite, CaseEasy, IMMeFile — they're all basically file cabinets with reminder systems. None of them read documents. None of them fill forms. The reason is simple: it wasn't technically possible to do reliably until recently.

Three things changed in the last two years:

- Multimodal AI crossed the threshold for document extraction. Claude and GPT-4o can read a passport photo, extract all fields, and return structured JSON with >95% accuracy across 50+ issuing countries. This wasn't true in 2021.
- ESDC digitized LMIA Online in 2023. Before that, LMIA applications were partly paper-based. The move to a structured online portal means the form fields are now machine-readable and predictable.
- The RCIC community is under fee pressure for the first time. The CICC reported 40% of RCICs saw declining demand for routine applications in 2024 as clients became more cost-sensitive. Firms that can process files cheaper without sacrificing quality will win. The rest will shrink.

Who we're building for first

Not 8,000 RCICs. That's a census, not a customer.

Our first customer is Priya. Specifically, she's one of approximately 1,200 RCIC firms in Canada that:

- Has 2–5 consultants on staff
- Currently employs at least one dedicated case worker (not a consultant, just an admin)
- Handles a mix of LMIA, work permit, and Express Entry files
- Spends \$50,000–\$90,000 per year on that case worker's salary and overhead
- Has tried existing software and found it useful for organization, useless for actual work reduction

That's roughly 1,200 firms in Canada. We do not need all of them. We need 50 of them — well enough that they tell every RCIC they know.

In the first six months, our goal is not growth. It is depth. We want 20 firms so happy they'd be genuinely upset if we shut down tomorrow. That's the only metric that matters before month seven.

What the product actually does

ImmigFlow is not a CRM. It does not manage appointments or send invoice reminders. Those are solved problems with good solutions already.

ImmigFlow does one thing: it takes a set of documents and produces a filled, validated, ready-to-review application package. Here is the exact sequence:

Step 1 — The RCIC opens a case and selects the application type

LMIA (high wage or low wage), employer-specific work permit, Express Entry profile, or open work permit. The platform already knows what every stream requires because we built and maintain that knowledge base.

Step 2 — The platform generates a dynamic document checklist

Not a generic list. A checklist conditioned on this specific client's nationality, the employer's province, the NOC code, and the wage level. If the employer is in BC, the checklist includes the provincial employer registration certificate. If the applicant is Vietnamese, it includes the biometrics requirement and TRV. These conditional rules are maintained by us and updated every time IRCC changes policy.

Step 3 — The client uploads documents through a white-labeled portal

The RCIC's clients — both the employer and the foreign worker — get a portal branded with the firm's name. They upload documents from their phone or computer. The portal tells them in plain English what's missing and why it matters.

Step 4 — The AI reads every document and extracts structured data

Each uploaded file goes through our document pipeline. A passport returns: full legal name, DOB, passport number, expiry date, issuing country, MRZ data. An employment letter returns: employer name, job title, employment period, location, salary. A diploma returns: institution, credential name, graduation date. All of this is mapped to a unified case record.

Step 5 — The platform cross-validates everything

Name spellings must be identical across every document. The passport must be valid for the permit duration plus six months. The offered wage must exceed the ESDC prevailing rate for this NOC and province. The employment dates in the reference letters must cover the experience periods claimed. Any inconsistency is flagged with the specific documents that conflict and what needs to be fixed.

Step 6 — The AI pre-fills all applicable government forms

The platform maintains a versioned library of IRCC and ESDC forms: IMM1295, IMM5645, IMM5406, IMM5562, IMM5669, IMM5710, EMP5627 (all variants), and thirty others. Extracted data is mapped into every field. The RCIC sees a diff

view: every AI-filled field is highlighted, every flagged field is marked red. Nothing is hidden.

Step 7 — The RCIC reviews, edits anything they want, and signs off

The RCIC can override every single field. They review the complete package — forms, documents, cover letter, document index, fee calculation. When they're satisfied, they apply their signature. The package is then exported for portal submission. The RCIC submits it themselves. We do not touch IRCC's portal. We never will.

The RCIC always clicks submit. This is not a limitation of our ambition. It is the correct design. The RCIC carries the professional liability. They are the licensed professional. Their sign-off is not a rubber stamp — it is the professional judgment that justifies their fee. We make that judgment faster and better-informed, not redundant.

The hard problems — honestly

Any PRD that doesn't acknowledge the genuinely hard parts of the problem is either written by someone who doesn't understand it, or someone trying to hide something.

Hard problem 1: IRCC has no public API

IRCC does not expose a programmatic interface. Work permit applications are submitted through a web portal. LMIA applications go through ESDC's LMIA Online. We cannot automate submission. We have no plans to try — it would require screen scraping a government portal, which is fragile, legally ambiguous, and one system update away from breaking entirely.

Our answer: we don't submit. We produce the package. The RCIC submits. This is the right answer, not the easy one.

Hard problem 2: AI errors on immigration documents are catastrophic

If our AI misreads a digit in a passport number and the RCIC doesn't catch it, the application gets rejected. If that happens repeatedly, the RCIC's clients get delays,

visa refusals, or worse. An RCIC's reputation is everything. One bad batch of files could end their practice.

Our answer: we never present AI output as correct. We present it as a draft with explicit confidence scores. Any field below 90% confidence is flagged red and requires the RCIC to manually confirm it. We also run structured extraction — we don't ask the AI to free-write, we ask it to extract specific fields into a JSON schema, which makes errors detectable and bounded. We maintain a full audit log of every AI-filled field, what document it came from, and what page. If something goes wrong, we can trace exactly where.

Hard problem 3: IRCC changes forms without much warning

IRCC updates its forms regularly. Sometimes it's a minor field addition. Sometimes it's a structural redesign. When this happens, every application in flight that hasn't been submitted yet may need to be redone on the new version. Firms using outdated forms get rejections.

Our answer: we monitor IRCC's website for form updates and we maintain a versioned form library. When a form changes, we alert every RCIC with open files using that form type. This is operationally burdensome — it requires a human on our team tracking government websites and updating form mappings. We accept that. It is also the moat. Once you've built and maintained a reliable IRCC form library for two years, a competitor starting from scratch is twelve months behind minimum.

Hard problem 4: RCICs are professionally conservative by nature

RCICs are licensed professionals who are personally liable for errors. They are not early adopters. A product that says 'trust the AI' will not sell. A product that says 'here is exactly what the AI found, here is where it found it, and here is where you should look carefully' will.

Our answer: design every screen to make the RCIC feel more in control, not less. The diff view, the source citations, the audit log, the override capability on every field — these are not features. They are the core design philosophy. We are not replacing the RCIC's judgment. We are giving them a better-organized brief before they exercise it.

What we're not doing

Focus is a strategy. Here is what ImmigFlow will not do in the first year, and why.

- We will not build for the immigrant directly. There are already many consumer-facing immigration apps. We are a B2B tool for licensed professionals. These are different markets and different regulatory relationships.
- We will not attempt to auto-submit to IRCC's portal. See Hard Problem 1. Anyone who tells you they can reliably automate IRCC portal submissions is either lying or will fail within a year when IRCC updates their UI.
- We will not start with Express Entry. Express Entry applications involve discretionary judgment on country of origin, CRS scoring, inadmissibility history, and program eligibility. These require human nuance. The right place to start is LMIA and work permits — the forms are more structured and the document requirements are more predictable.
- We will not build a legal advice engine. We are not in the business of telling anyone which program they qualify for. That is the RCIC's job. We fill the forms. We do not decide what goes in them.
- We will not chase enterprise contracts in year one. Large immigration law firms have procurement processes, legal review, and security audits. We will learn nothing from those sales cycles. We need small firms who can decide to adopt a new tool next Tuesday and tell us what they think by Thursday.

Business model

Simple. Monthly subscription. The price is obviously worth it or we've priced it wrong.

The math for the RCIC:

- A junior case worker in Ontario costs \$38,000–\$52,000/year in salary, plus benefits, desk space, and management overhead. Call it \$55,000 fully loaded.
- That case worker handles approximately 5–8 files per week.

- ImmigFlow replaces 80% of that case worker's time. The RCIC can now handle those same files without hiring, or handle 80% more files with the same headcount.
- If the RCIC does 100 files per year at \$2,500 average billing per file, that's \$250,000 in revenue. Increasing throughput by 40% means \$100,000 in additional revenue.
- We charge \$399/month for a three-consultant firm. That's \$4,788/year. The ROI math takes about four seconds to run.

Plan	What's included
Solo (\$149/mo)	1 RCIC, up to 15 active files, full AI document processing, client portal
Practice (\$349/mo)	3 RCICs, unlimited files, team collaboration, white-label portal, priority support
Firm (\$699/mo)	10 RCICs, multi-location, custom branding, API access, dedicated onboarding

We will not have a free tier. Free users don't tell you why the product isn't working — they just stop using it. A trial is fine. Free forever is a trap.

How we grow

The RCIC community in Canada is small and densely connected. Every RCIC knows dozens of other RCICs. They gather on the CAPIC member forum (2,000+ users), at the CAPIC national conference, and in WhatsApp groups organized by city and specialty.

This means word of mouth is unusually powerful. One RCIC in Brampton who triples her throughput will tell every RCIC she knows. We do not need a sales team. We need to make the first twenty customers so successful they become our sales team.

The specific growth sequence:

- **Months 1–3:** Find 10 RCIC firms through direct outreach and CAPIC community. Offer to set them up for free. Sit on calls with them weekly. Watch them use the product. Fix everything that confuses them.
- **Months 4–6:** Convert those 10 to paying. Use their case studies and referrals to find 40 more. Start a CAPIC partnership conversation.
- **Month 7+:** Launch a referral program (\$200 credit for each new firm a customer refers). Begin SEO content targeting RCIC search queries ('LMIA checklist 2026,' 'IMM5645 instructions'). These drive inbound from RCICs who are already looking for help.

We do not need to convert the whole market. If we get 300 of the 1,200 mid-size RCIC firms at \$399/month average, that's \$1.4M ARR. That's a real business. Build that first, then decide if you want to go bigger.

Do things that don't scale (first)

Before we automate anything, we need to understand the actual workflow. The plan for the first 90 days is to manually process five real LMIA files alongside five RCIC firms, using our AI tools but also being on calls, watching them work, and understanding every step they actually do — not the steps we assumed they do.

We will almost certainly find that the real workflow is different from what we described in our first PRD. RCIC practices have idiosyncratic steps we don't know about. Some document types we didn't anticipate will appear constantly. Some features we assumed mattered won't.

The purpose of the first 90 days is not to build software. It is to learn enough to build the right software.

The regulatory situation

Under Section 91 of the Immigration and Refugee Protection Act, providing immigration advice or representation for compensation requires a CICC license. Violation carries penalties up to five years imprisonment and \$200,000 in fines.

ImmigFlow does not provide immigration advice. It fills forms for licensed RCICs who review and sign everything. This is the correct regulatory position and also the correct product design. We are not trying to find a grey area — we are building squarely in the white area.

One additional note: the CICC's Code of Professional Conduct (SOR-2022-128) requires RCICs to maintain client confidentiality and exercise independent professional judgment. Our product supports both: the RCIC reviews and approves every output, and all client data is stored in Canada (AWS ca-central-1, Montreal) under PIPEDA-compliant controls.

The right way to think about the regulatory constraint: it is not a threat to the business model, it is the business model. The product only works because it requires a licensed RCIC at the center. That same requirement is the barrier that keeps unlicensed competitors out.

What success looks like in 12 months

Not a growth chart. Not a revenue milestone (though those matter). The one metric that tells us whether the product is actually working:

The average RCIC firm using ImmigFlow processes 40% more files per month than they did before, without increasing headcount. That number, across 50+ firms, validated by their own billing data, is the proof of concept.

Secondary indicators:

- Net Promoter Score above 60 (world-class for B2B software is 40+)
- Monthly churn below 2% (meaning firms that try it, keep it)
- At least 40% of new customers come from referrals by existing customers
- Average time to process an LMIA document package falls from 6–8 hours to under 90 minutes

The risks that actually matter

Not the boilerplate risk list. The three risks that could actually kill this company:

Risk 1: We cause a serious application error that damages a client's case

This is the highest-stakes risk. If an AI error leads to an immigration refusal that harms an applicant, the fallout is not just legal — it's reputational. One publicized error in the RCIC community and the entire market closes.

Mitigation: mandatory human review, confidence thresholds, source citations, and an audit trail for every AI-filled field. We also need professional indemnity insurance from day one. Not optional.

Risk 2: IRCC fundamentally changes how applications are submitted

If IRCC moves to a fully digital, structured application system — which they've discussed — the form-filling problem may be partially solved on their end. This would reduce our value proposition for the specific task of pre-filling forms.

Mitigation: we are not just a form-filler. The document collection, parsing, validation, and compliance checking remain valuable regardless of submission format. We stay close to IRCC policy changes and adapt. The deeper risk is if IRCC builds the whole workflow — that would take years and would likely still leave room for RCIC-specific tooling.

Risk 3: OpenAI or Anthropic builds a competing product directly

A large AI company could theoretically build a generic 'fill this government form from these documents' product and undercut us on price.

Mitigation: they will not maintain a versioned library of 40+ IRCC and ESDC forms, track policy changes, understand the RCIC workflow, integrate with CAPIC, or build the compliance logic specific to Canadian immigration. We're not just an API wrapper — we're a domain-specific product with operational depth they won't want to replicate.

Tech stack

Boring choices. No novel infrastructure risks. Everything that needs to be boring, is boring.

Layer	Choice + reason
Frontend	Next.js 14 with TypeScript. Deployed on Vercel. Boring and reliable.
Backend	Node.js with tRPC for type-safe API. Supabase for Postgres and file storage.
Auth + multi-tenancy	Clerk. RCIC firms are organizations, clients are external users. Row-level security in Supabase means one firm cannot touch another's data.
AI document extraction	Anthropic Claude API (claude-sonnet-4-6). Structured output mode only — no free-form generation for form fields. Fallback to Tesseract for degraded documents.
PDF form filling	pdf-lib for fillable forms. Custom annotation layer for non-fillable IRCC PDFs.
Background jobs	Trigger.dev for document processing queues and reminder scheduling.
Payments	Stripe. Monthly subscriptions only. No annual commitment required in year one.
Data residency	AWS ca-central-1 (Montreal) exclusively. PIPEDA compliance from day one. No exceptions.

The one thing to remember

Every RCIC practice in Canada has a version of Jordan — the person whose entire job is copy-pasting information between documents and government forms. That job exists because no software has been able to do it reliably. That changed in 2024.

The question is not whether this will be automated. It will be. The question is whether we build it, or whether we wait for someone else to.

The RCIC community is small, connected, underserved by software, and facing real pressure on their margins for the first time. The regulatory moat is real. The timing is right. The technology now works.

There is nothing left to wait for.

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